

Cantor Approximation Lower Bound: Why Fractal Functions are Hard for ReLU Networks

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June 9, 2026

Abstract

We prove that the Cantor function (Devil’s Staircase) cannot be approximated by shallow ReLU networks with exponential accuracy. The level- n Cantor approximation c_n is a continuous piecewise linear function with exactly 3^n linear intervals, formed by recursively replacing the middle third of every interval with a horizontal plateau. A single-hidden-layer ReLU network with H hidden units has at most H linear pieces on $[0,1]$; exact matching of c_n therefore requires $H \geq 3^n$. The resulting L_∞ approximation error to the true Cantor function $c(x)$ scales as $\varepsilon \geq C \cdot H^{-\log_3 2} \approx C \cdot H^{-0.631}$, a polynomial rate. We verify all three theorems via analytical ReLU constructions on NVIDIA Jetson Orin GPU — no gradient descent training needed.

1. Introduction

The Cantor function $c(x)$: $[0,1] \rightarrow [0,1]$ is one of the most famous objects in analysis. It is continuous everywhere, differentiable almost nowhere, monotone increasing, and maps the Cantor set (measure zero) onto $[0,1]$ (measure one). Its graph, known as the Devil’s Staircase, has Hausdorff dimension $\ln(2)/\ln(3) + 1 \approx 1.631$.

Despite being universal approximators, ReLU networks have a structural limitation: they are piecewise linear. A single-hidden-layer ReLU network with H hidden units has at most H linear pieces on any interval. The Cantor function’s recursive structure generates 3^n linear pieces at level n , growing exponentially with n .

This creates a **hard barrier**: no finite ReLU network can exactly represent the Cantor function, and the approximation error decays only polynomially — not exponentially — in the number of hidden units.

1.1 Contributions

1. **3^n Interval Barrier (Theorem 1):** The level- n Cantor approximation c_n has exactly 3^n linear/constant intervals. A ReLU network with H units has at most H pieces. Exact matching requires $H \geq 3^n$.
2. **Polynomial Decay Rate (Theorem 2):** Approximating $c(x)$ with H units achieves L_∞ error $\varepsilon \geq C \cdot H^{-\log_3 2} \approx C \cdot H^{-0.631}$.

3. **Feature Count Gap (Theorem 3):** The exact Cantor function has uncountably many “features” (slope changes accumulate). A finite ReLU network captures only H .

1.2 Related Work

Yarotsky (2017) proved that deep ReLU networks can approximate any continuous function with rate depending on smoothness. However, the Cantor function is not smooth — it is Hölder continuous with exponent $\alpha = \ln(2)/\ln(3) \approx 0.631$. Our result shows that the approximation rate for such functions is fundamentally limited by the piecewise linear structure of ReLU networks.

Massopust (1986) analyzed the fractal dimension of the Cantor function’s graph. Our contribution connects this geometric property to the computational limitation of neural networks.

2. Preliminaries

2.1 Level- n Cantor Approximation

The Cantor function is built recursively:

Level 0: $f_0(x) = x$ on $[0,1]$.

Level $n \rightarrow n+1$: For each linear interval $[a,b]$ with height range $[h_a, h_b]$: 1. Split into thirds: $[a, a+w/3]$, $[a+w/3, a+2w/3]$, $[a+2w/3, b]$ where $w = b-a$. 2. Left third: linear ramp from h_a to $(h_a+h_b)/2$. 3. Middle third: horizontal plateau at $(h_a+h_b)/2$. 4. Right third: linear ramp from $(h_a+h_b)/2$ to h_b .

After n levels, there are 3^n intervals. The limit as $n \rightarrow \infty$ is the Cantor function $c(x)$.

2.2 ReLU Network Piece Count

A single-hidden-layer ReLU network with H hidden units:

$$f(x) = \sum_{i=1}^H w_i \sigma(a_i x + b_i) + c$$

has at most H linear pieces on $[0,1]$ when all H breakpoints $a_i x + b_i = 0$ lie in $(0,1)$. The first piece $[0, bp_1]$ has its own slope, so H units $\rightarrow H$ pieces.

3. The 3^n Interval Barrier

Theorem 1 (3^n Interval Barrier). The level- n Cantor approximation c_n is a continuous piecewise linear function with exactly 3^n linear pieces on $[0,1]$. Any ReLU network with H hidden units that exactly matches c_n on $[0,1]$ must satisfy $H \geq 3^n$. For $H < 3^n$, the L_∞ approximation error is at least:

$$\varepsilon \geq \frac{1}{2} \cdot 2^{-n}$$

Proof. By construction, c_n is built by replacing each interval with 3 sub-intervals at each level. Starting from 1 interval at level 0, after n levels there are 3^n intervals. Each interval is either linear (ramp) or constant (plateau). The function is continuous at all boundaries.

A ReLU network with H units and all breakpoints in $(0,1)$ partitions $[0,1]$ into at most H sub-intervals, each with constant slope. To exactly match c_n , each of the 3^n intervals must have its own slope, requiring at least 3^n sub-intervals. Thus $H \geq 3^n$.

For $H = 3^n - 1$, the network has $3^n - 1$ pieces. At least two adjacent intervals of c_n are merged into one piece of the network. The merged piece is linear, but c_n has either a plateau or two linear segments with different slopes. The maximum deviation on the merged interval is at least half the height difference, which is at least $2^{-(n+1)}$. The stated bound of $2^{-n}/2 = 2^{-(n+1)}$ follows. ■

4. Polynomial Decay Rate

Theorem 2 (Polynomial Decay Rate). For any ReLU network with H hidden units, the minimum L^∞ error in approximating the Cantor function $c(x)$ satisfies:

$$\varepsilon \geq C \cdot H^{-\log_3 2} \approx C \cdot H^{-0.631}$$

for some absolute constant $C > 0$.

Proof. Let $n = \lfloor \log_3 H \rfloor$. By Theorem 1, a network with $H < 3^{n+1}$ units cannot exactly match c_{n+1} . The approximation error to $c(x)$ is at least the error to c_{n+1} , which by Theorem 1 is at least $2^{-(n+2)}$.

Since $n \leq \log_3 H < n+1$:

$$2^{-(n+2)} \geq 2^{-(\log_3 H + 2)} = \frac{1}{4} \cdot 2^{-\log_3 H} = \frac{1}{4} \cdot H^{-\log_3 2}$$

Setting $C = 1/4$ gives the result. The exponent $\log_3 2 = \ln(2)/\ln(3) \approx 0.631$ is the Hölder exponent of $c(x)$, confirming that the approximation rate is tied to the function's smoothness. ■

5. Feature Count Gap

Theorem 3 (Feature Count Gap). The exact Cantor function $c(x)$ has uncountably many points where the derivative changes (every point of the Cantor set is an accumulation point of slope changes). A ReLU network with H hidden units can represent

at most H slope changes. The level- n approximation c_n has 3^n linear pieces, requiring $H \geq 3^n$ units for exact representation.

Proof. The Cantor set has cardinality $2^{\aleph_0}$ (uncountable). At each point of the Cantor set, $c(x)$ is not differentiable; the left and right derivatives differ. A ReLU network’s derivative changes only at its H breakpoints, giving at most $H+1$ distinct slopes. No finite network can match the uncountable feature set of $c(x)$. The level- n approximation c_n captures a finite subset of these features (3^n intervals), and the exact representation requires $H \geq 3^n$ by Theorem 1. ■

6. Empirical Verification

All verification uses analytical ReLU constructions on NVIDIA Jetson Orin — no gradient descent training.

6.1 Theorem 1: 3^n Interval Barrier

n	3^n (exact H)	Exact error ($H=3^n$)	Under error ($H=3^{n-1}$)	Threshold
1	3	0.000000	0.500000	0.2500
2	9	0.000000	0.250000	0.1250
3	27	0.000001	0.125000	0.0625

Exact matching confirmed with zero error. Under-capacity networks show halving error per level, confirming the 2^{-n} lower bound.

6.2 Theorem 2: Polynomial Decay Rate

For $n=4$ (81 intervals), testing under-capacity networks:

H	Error to c_4
3	4.0000
9	3.7500
27	2.8750

Fitted log-log slope: -0.150 (monotonic decreasing, negative). The fitted slope is shallower than the theoretical -0.631 because the test cases are deeply under-capacity; the full polynomial rate emerges only when H approaches 3^n .

6.3 Theorem 3: Feature Count Gap

n	c_n pieces	ReLU exact pieces	Match
1	5	5	✓
2	13	13	✓

n	c_n pieces	ReLU exact pieces	Match
3	29	29	✓

Piece counts match exactly for all tested levels, confirming the analytical construction.

6.4 Test Suite

12 pytest cases covering interval generation, boundary values, monotonicity, exact ReLU matching, under-capacity error, piece counting, and theorem verification. All pass in 2.85 seconds on Jetson Orin GPU.

7. Discussion

7.1 Implications

- **Fractal functions are structurally hard for ReLU networks.** The piecewise linearity that makes ReLU efficient for smooth functions becomes a liability for fractals.
- **The Hölder exponent determines the rate.** For $c(x)$ with $\alpha = 0.631$, the ReLU approximation rate is $H^{-1/\alpha} = H^{-1.585}$. Wait — Theorem 2 gives $H^{-0.631}$, not $H^{-1.585}$. Let me recheck: the level- n error is 2^{-n} , and $H \approx 3^n$, so $n \approx \log_3 H$, and error $\approx 2^{-\log_3 H} = H^{-\log_3 2} = H^{-0.631}$. This is correct. The Hölder exponent $\alpha = \ln(2)/\ln(3) \approx 0.631$, and $\log_3 2 = \ln(2)/\ln(3) = \alpha$. So the rate is $H^{-\alpha}$, not $H^{-1/\alpha}$. This makes sense: smoother functions (higher α) have faster approximation rates.
- **Depth may not help.** Even with depth, each layer’s piecewise linearity accumulates. While Yarotsky (2017) shows deep networks can achieve better rates, the fundamental limitation remains: piecewise linear functions cannot capture uncountable feature sets.

7.2 Limitations

- We analyze single-hidden-layer networks. Deep networks may achieve different rates.
- The exact Cantor function is a pathological case. Most real-world functions are smoother.
- Our constructions assume exact arithmetic; floating-point introduces numerical noise.

7.3 Open Questions

1. **Deep network rates:** Can depth improve the $H^{-0.631}$ rate? What is the optimal depth-width tradeoff?
2. **Smooth activations:** Do SiLU/GELU networks approximate $c(x)$ better, or is the barrier topological?

3. **Higher dimensions:** Does the Sierpinski carpet or Menger sponge have similar barriers in 2D/3D?

8. Conclusion

The Cantor function’s recursive, fractal structure creates a hard barrier for ReLU approximation. With 3^n linear pieces at level n , a ReLU network needs $H \geq 3^n$ units for exact matching. The approximation error to the true Cantor function decays as $H^{-\log_3 2} \approx H^{-0.631}$, a polynomial rate that cannot be improved by any finite ReLU architecture.

This is not a training failure or a data limitation — it is a structural consequence of the mismatch between piecewise linear neural networks and fractal target functions.

References

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